

Finding A Sustainable Consensus

A Shared Duty to Mitigate Climate Change

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Executive Summary

2023 has been a year characterized by extreme weather conditions, deviating far from the norm with every part of the country economically and physically feeling the effects of climate change. Therefore, it is time to recognize that it is a bipartisan issue. Based on public opinion polls, recommendations include placing accountability on corporations and incentivizing the implementation of environment-friendly regulations, acknowledging how opinions within the Republican party vary on age and political ideology, and increasing outreach with constituents to improve public understanding of the topic.

Place The Focus On Corporations

The slogan 'Reuse, Reduce, Recycle' has been used to promote the individual's role in protecting the environment. While it is important to advocate being aware of one's part, it perpetuates the misconception that it is primarily the individual consumer's responsibility. It overlooks the fact that "100 active fossil fuel producers are linked to 71% of global industrial greenhouse gasses".¹ The average American household emits just 48 metric tons CO₂e a year², while the U.S. emits 6,340 million metric tons of CO₂ a year.³

This sentiment is reflected as 69% of US adults believe that large businesses and corporations are doing too little to help reduce the effects of global climate change. 62% think that the energy industry does too little as well.

Almost the majority (48%) think that they are doing about the right amount to help reduce the effects of global climate change, but 66% believe that ordinary Americans are doing too little. This contradictory statement highlights how there is a tendency to be self-confident, yet concerned about the actions of others, or the perceived lack thereof.

Republicans Are More Diverse Than You Think...

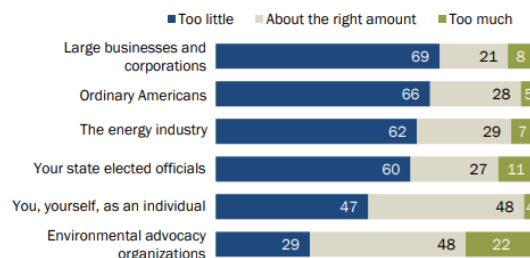
While it can be easy to generalize political parties, it can be insightful to recognize the internal differences and nuances. This includes generational and ideological differences.

Generational Differences

Republican and Republican-leaning individuals showcase differences in their prioritization of significant lifestyle changes and efforts to reduce the effects of climate change for future generations. Around half of Republican and Republican-leaning Gen Z respondents say reducing climate change for the

Majorities say large businesses, energy industry and ordinary Americans are doing too little on climate

% of U.S. adults who say each of the following are doing ____ to help reduce the effects of global climate change



Note: Respondents who did not give an answer are not shown.

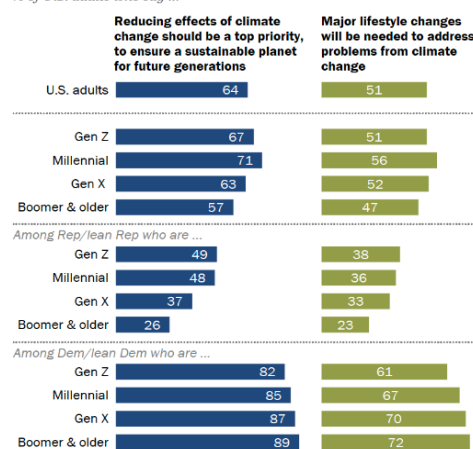
Source: Survey conducted April 20-29, 2021.

Gen Z, Millennials Stand Out for Climate Change Activism, Social Media Engagement With Issue

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Younger Republicans more likely than older to prioritize reducing effects of climate change now

% of U.S. adults who say ...



Note: Respondents who gave other responses or did not give an answer are not shown.

Source: Survey conducted April 20-29, 2021.

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¹ New report shows just 100 companies are source of over 70% of emissions—CDP. (n.d.). Retrieved December 6, 2023, from <https://www.cdp.net/en/articles/media/new-report-shows-just-100-companies-are-source-of-over-70-of-emissions>

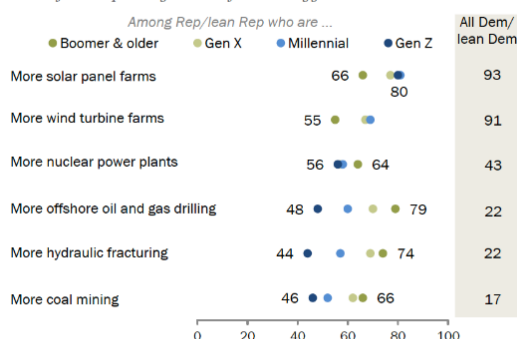
² Jones, C. M., & Kammen, D. M. (2011). Quantifying Carbon Footprint Reduction Opportunities for U.S. Households and Communities. *Environmental Science & Technology*, 45(9), 4088–4095. <https://doi.org/10.1021/es102221h>

³ US EPA, O. (2017, February 8). *Inventory of U.S. Greenhouse Gas Emissions and Sinks* [Reports and Assessments]. <https://www.epa.gov/ghgemissions/inventory-us-greenhouse-gas-emissions-and-sinks>

next generation is a top priority, compared to the 26% of Boomer and older generation respondents who think the same. Republican and Republican-leaning Gen Z respondents are also more likely than their older generations to believe that major lifestyle changes will be needed to address climate change.

Among Republicans, support for expanding use of fossil fuel sources is lower among Gen Z, Millennials

% who favor expanding the use of each energy source



Note: There is insufficient sample size to report Gen Z Republicans' views of wind turbine farms because the question was asked of half the sample. Respondents who did not give an answer are not shown.

Source: Survey conducted April 20-29, 2021.

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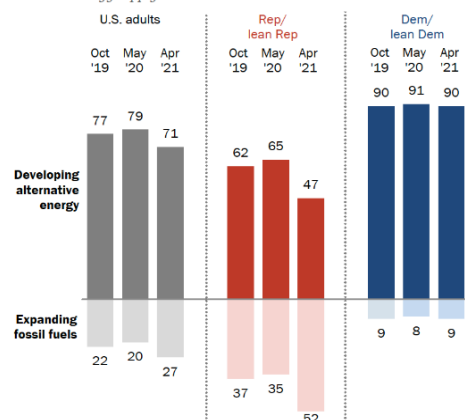
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Ideological Differences

In today's political climate, ideology has increasingly become synonymous with political party identification, significantly contributing to the escalating polarization of parties and their respective issues. By

Most Democrats prioritize alternative energy development, Republicans are now divided

% of U.S. adults who say the more important priority for addressing America's energy supply should be ...



Note: Respondents who did not give an answer are not shown.

Source: Survey conducted April 20-29, 2021.

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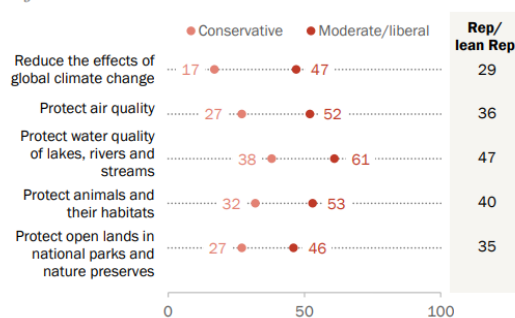
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Younger Republican and Republican-leaning voters show a preference for greener energy sources, differing from older generations who tend to favor drilling, hydraulic fracturing, and mining.

This indicates that there is a shifting trend within the Republican Party, which over time, may result in an increasing majority of Republicans who support legislation and other efforts to mitigate climate change and, in turn, protect the environment.

Moderate Republicans more likely than conservative Republicans to say the federal government is doing too little on key environmental protections

% of Republicans and Republican leaners who say the federal government is doing too little to ...



Note: Respondents who gave other responses or did not give an answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted May 30-June 4, 2023.

"Majorities of Americans Prioritize Renewable Energy, Back Steps to Address Climate Change"

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examining the ideological variation within the

Republican party, a consistent distinction can be made between conservatives and those who identify themselves as moderate or liberal. There is a sentiment among the latter group that the federal government should do more to protect the quality of air and water, wildlife, ecosystems, and open lands within protected areas.

There is a discernible division among Republicans when it comes to addressing America's energy supply. There is a clear split between those who support developing alternative energy and those who would prefer expanding fossil fuels. In 2019 and 2020,

62% and 65%, respectively, favored developing alternative energy sources, with the remaining 37% and 35% endorsing expanding fossil fuels. Republican voters can and will support climate-friendly efforts. While 52% of Republicans in 2021 favored expanding fossil fuels, the other 47% sponsored the development of alternative energy sources, signaling only a slight marginal difference.

Why Bipartisanship? Because Climate Change Does Not Care About Your Politics

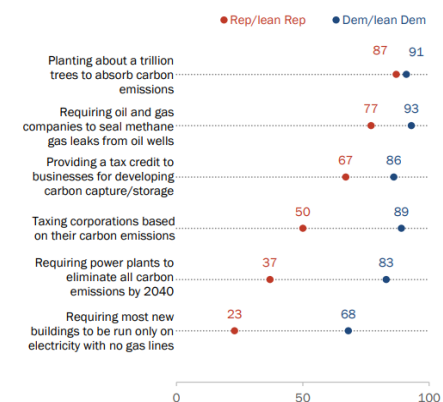
Climate change impacts everyone. Recent weather conditions have been characterized by below- and above-average temperatures, extremely dry or wet conditions, intensified by flooding, tornadoes, and Nor'easters. By the end of April, "the U.S. was struck with seven separate weather and climate disasters, each with losses exceeding \$1 billion" surpassing the total cost of "\$19 billion and resulted in 97 direct and indirect casualties."⁴ These ethical and economic impacts of climate change must be recognized and addressed.

Incentivizing Is (Ever)green

There is a consensus for various solutions, with a majority calling for corporations to increase their efforts. 85% of US adults support requiring oil

Majority of Republicans favor providing a tax credit to businesses for developing carbon capture technology

% of U.S. adults who say they *favor* the following proposals to reduce the effects of climate change

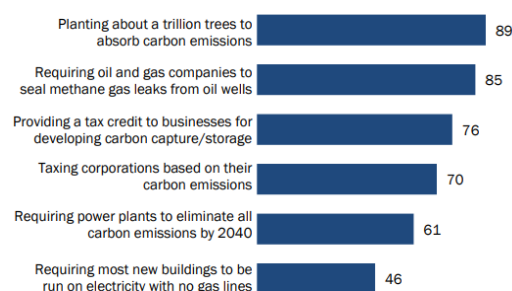


Note: Respondents who gave other responses or did not give an answer are not shown.
Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted May 30-Jun. 4, 2023.
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Majority of Americans support requiring power plants to eliminate all carbon emissions by 2040

% of U.S. adults who say they *favor* the following proposals to reduce the effects of climate change



Note: Respondents who gave other responses or did not give an answer are not shown.
Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted May 30-Jun. 4, 2023.
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and gas companies to seal methane leaks from oil wells. With 70% endorsing taxing corporations based on their carbon emissions and 76%

supporting providing a tax credit to businesses for developing carbon capture and storage. Introducing the application of incentives to the process of climate policymaking, it stimulates the development of climate-friendly regulations and legislation in the future.

These initiatives have majority support among Republicans, as 77% favor requiring oil and gas companies to seal methane gas leaks from oil wells, 67% support offering tax incentives for developing carbon capture and storage technologies and 50%

endorse taxing corporations based on their carbon emissions. Having corporations address their role and involvement in exacerbating climate change is a widely embraced initiative and promotes a proactive commitment to protecting the environment.

⁴ U.S. dominated by remarkable warmth so far in 2023 | National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. (2023, May 8). <https://www.noaa.gov/news/us-dominated-by-remarkable-warmth-so-far-in-2023>

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